My typically frenetic schedule gave me only three days at home between returning from New Zealand and flying to Bangalore for the start of the Indian Premier League, but I made arrangements to have lunch with the Swart family. It was becoming a military operation and, in a brief window of opportunity when Danielle and Alida stepped away from the table, John discreetly passed me a package containing the engagement ring.

Everything was going according to plan.

I had invited Danielle to spend some time with me in India and, knowing she had always wanted to visit the Taj Mahal, suggested we organise a trip during a break between RCB matches.

'Jim Rydell and Kalveer B Biradar are going to travel with us,' I said.

'Why?'

'There will be crowds, and they will be our security guards.'

That was a tiny white lie. In truth, Jim was a professional photographer and Kalveer was a videographer. Both are closely associated with RCB, and have become good friends, and I wanted them to be present to record the events that would, all going well, unfold during our visit. So the four of us flew to Delhi, hired a car and made the 212-kilometre drive to Agra in Uttar Pradesh. We eventually checked in at the Oberoi Amarvilas hotel and, while Danielle went to change, Jim fixed a hidden microphone inside my shirt.

The Taj Mahal, this staggeringly perfect marble mausoleum commissioned by the Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan in memory of his wife Mumtaz Mahal, was described by Nobel laureate Rabindranath Tagore as 'a teardrop on the cheek of time' and it seems to evoke strong emotions in almost every visitor. As far as I was concerned, it was the ideal place to pop the question, the ideal place to get engaged.

We walked around the main building, and then made our way to a nearby lawn. The sun was just starting to set. Danielle looked fantastic in a simple white dress and, out of the corner of my eye, I noticed Jim